were primarily aimed to supply its armed forces with the latest available weapon systems and military technology and to build a more modern and powerful defence establishment. The CIA officers believed India's first move to shop outside the USSR in the 1980s also served to reduce criticism at home and abroad of India being a Soviet proxy by reducing the Soviet share of overall Indian military imports.

In 1983, a CIA intelligence note said:

Achieving a better balance of Western and Soviet arms, however, will be a slow, long-term process, and Western arms sales to India over the next five years are likely to be a comparatively small, albeit important, part of the overall modernization process. The Indian armed forces probably will seek selected weapons from the United States, and, in so doing, are likely to request progressively more sophisticated military technology. Prime Minister Gandhi, however, is likely to proceed slowly in concluding new major arms contracts with the United States because of suspicions of US intentions in the region and dislike for US foreign military restrictions.

And then in 1986, the Indian government signed a $285 million contract with the Swedish arms company Bofors for four hundred and ten Howitzer field guns. A year later, the deal turned out to be a massive scam, triggering a political storm in New Delhi. The opposition hammered Rajiv Gandhi's government as the alleged middleman in the deal, Ottavio Quattrochi, was closely linked to his family. It was during this period that R&AW officers posted abroad began verifying the credentials of arms sellers. Information picked up from assets and paid informers hired for limited operations was passed on to the government. Although the spy agency's role was limited